



122 Laser printing Solutions



134 How IP Phones Work



142 Blogging for Professionals

Digital Business

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Case Study

IT Cuts Red Tape

To many, e-governance and a paperless office are Utopian ideas. Not for the Tamil Nadu government's IT Department, which uses software to create a transparent transaction process

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Information Technology (IT) has today become an integral part of governance, especially in India. It is viewed as a tool that will help deliver services, both in the public and the private sector, to the common man.

E-governance, as a concept, is leveraging IT to streamline the administrative process—it involves computerisation of records, facilitating efficient transactions between various government departments, networking offices, and using Web sites and e-mail to bring administrators closer to people.

In the past decade, e-governance has emerged a popular buzzword among Indian politicians and bureaucrats alike. One quasi-Government organisation in Tamil Nadu, has decided to go the distance, by implementing e-governance at a micro-level—their office is now completely paperless and file-transfer takes place in an electronic format.

Using a tool titled “e-Administration”, Chennai-based Electronics Corporation of Tamil Nadu Ltd (ELCOT), with the help of an Information and Communication Technologies (ICT) organisation called Life-Line to Business (LL2B.com Pvt Ltd), has introduced a workflow and document-management process *sans* physical movement or use of paper.

ELCOT was designated by the Government of Tamil Nadu to promote IT industries statewide.

Apart from supporting IT entrepreneurs, it also promotes joint ventures in electronics, communication and IT. They also help develop infrastructure for the software industry by providing effective communication backbones and IT parks.

LL2B's “e-Administration” tool allows ELCOT officials to electronically sanction purchases, approve official activities and transfer files as well. All the files processed are made available on a central server, and the status of pending files can be obtained at any stage as well. Thus, the workflow is quite transparent. The only documents printed and filed are the final order copies.

The Nuts And Bolts

As part of its e-governance initiative, the Government of Tamil Nadu embarked on a paperless office drive for introducing transparency and accountability in its internal and external transactions.

ELCOT decided to introduce “e-Administration”—a paperless file-management system, which ensures speedy disposal of files. The entire process—creation, movement, monitoring, and approval of files takes place electronically, resulting in better utilisation of manpower. “This helps avoiding delays, which leads to better governance,” according to Sudeep Jain, (IAS) MD, ELCOT.

